

The Flexible Mind

Personal Rigidity and the Narratives We Refuse to Release

Backbone values engaged: Consciousness, Coherence, Wisdom, Truth, Respect.

This document is a reflective, personal-practice companion to the document “How Stories Start Wars and How to Change Them”. It does not change or soften the document’s secular, evidence-based method for governments - it sits beside it, for the steward doing the work, not the government adopting the framework.

Why This Document (The Flexible Mind) Exists, and Why It Is Separate

The document “How Stories Start Wars and How to Change Them” asks a practical, checkable question: is this story about another country fact, or framing? That question works the same whether the steward asking it is calm and open, or defensive and certain. But it is worth naming honestly that the steward's own state matters. A mind that is rigid -- certain that it already sees clearly, unwilling to hold a story loosely enough to actually examine it -- will apply even a good method poorly.

This document “The Flexible Mind” is about that inner condition. It is kept separate from the other document deliberately: a government adopting a six-step evidence-based protocol should never be asked to also adopt a spiritual worldview to use it. But the steward preparing to do this work, in their own time, may find real value in looking at their own rigidity first.

The Insight, in GSC's Own Words

The Indian teacher Sadhguru has written about rigidity as something that forms on several levels at once -- in the body, in thought, in emotion, and in a person's underlying energy -- and about how these are not separate problems but one interconnected condition. His central claim is that a mind convinced of its own correctness stops being able to perceive anything that would challenge it, and that this rigidity typically increases with age unless it is actively worked against. A second claim worth sitting with: that a settled, certain identity -- what he calls the ego -- often resists the very openness that would dissolve its certainty, because that openness feels like a threat to the self rather than an update to a belief.

Read this way, without the devotional framing, it is a strong psychological account of exactly the phenomenon in “How Stories Start Wars and How to Change Them” is described, at the level of nations: why simply presenting a government, a media outlet, or a public with accurate facts, so rarely dissolves a story they are already invested in. The investment is not really in the facts. It is in the self that the story has been built around. A country's narrative rigidity and a person's private rigidity, may be the same mechanism, operating at different scales.

Source for this reflection: Sadhguru, “Breaking Your Barriers of Rigidity,” Isha Foundation, Oct 26, 2015
<https://isha.sadhguru.org/en/wisdom/article/breaking-barriers-of-rigidity>

The Bridge to a Self-Audit Clause

The document “How Stories Start Wars and How to Change Them” requires that before any counter-narrative is published, its author applies the same scrutiny to their own draft that they apply to others - naming their own incentive, checking their own framing. That clause is easy to state and hard to actually practice, because the hardest bias to see is the one holding the pen. This document proposes that the self-audit clause has a felt, practiced version, not just a procedural one: before sitting down to analyze someone else's rigid story, a steward can spend a few minutes checking their own rigidity first -- physical, mental, and emotional -- using the reflection below.

A Short Practice Before Narrative Work

This is offered as a private, optional practice for a steward preparing to do the analytical work in Document 21 -- not a requirement, and not something to bring into a government-facing document.

- 1. Before opening the story you are about to analyze, notice your body. Are you sitting rigidly, jaw tight, breath shallow? Let it soften, without needing to know why.*
- 2. Ask yourself honestly: is there a version of this analysis I already want to arrive at? Name it, out loud or on paper, before you begin -- not to suppress it, but so you can notice if your reasoning quietly bends toward it.*
- 3. Hold the story you are examining the way you would hold something you might be wrong about, rather than something you already understand.*
- 4. When you feel certainty rising quickly -- a sense of “I already know what this is” -- treat that speed itself as information. Fast certainty is often rigidity wearing the mask of clarity.*
- 5. Only once the body and the reaction have settled, begin Step 1 of the six-step method: who is telling this story, and what do they gain if it is believed.*

The aim is not tranquility for its own sake. It is that a steward whose own mind is momentarily less rigid is simply more able to see a rigid story clearly -- including, when it is true, the rigidity in GSC's own prior drafts.

An Honest Limit

This reflection is offered as one useful lens among many, not as the only path to the same insight -- contemplative traditions across many cultures and secular psychology (particularly work on motivated reasoning and identity-protective cognition) describe closely related mechanisms without any spiritual framing at all. Readers who prefer a strictly secular account of why people resist correcting false beliefs should feel free to treat this document as optional, and to rely on the document (“How Stories Start Wars and How to Change Them”) alone, which requires no such framing.